

Protecting your social identity

Beware, someone might be engineering your identity online!

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In the 1995 cult geek movie *The Net*, Sandra Bullock plays your average, every day systems analyst whose interactions with work and friends, were solely online. Due to her pre-occupation with the online world, she rarely found time to prove her own identity when she suddenly found her credit cards invalidated, her home empty, and pretty much any record of her existence “deleted”. A decade ago, we would have looked at the film for its cheesiness and really questioned whether a government conspiracy could entangle anyone and steal their life via the Internet. Flash forward till now, and it’s come to a point where you never know who could be gathering information on you, or when.

In today’s world, where the number of devices connected to the Internet supercedes, we’re all living through the Internet in some form or another. The threat of imposters, who pretend to be you, is frightening and real. After all, how hard is it to glean one’s habits, hobbies, interests and professional experience? The damage that can be caused by ordinary people who can visit your profile, view your photo albums and friend lists, and see what makes you tick is equally devastating. When you look at the number of kids and pre-teens coming online, who aren’t aware of the ugliness hiding deep inside the Internet, it’s of tantamount importance to know just what to share and what not to. Protecting your social identity thus becomes a major priority for protecting not just yourself, but your friends and family.

Entrapment: How They Get Us

The number of activities and apps on Facebook alone has reached an almost infinite level of constant buzz. We no longer

look at them as separate from our very selves, for we are what we “Like”, and everyone should know who we are. Curiosity can get the better of one more often than not, however.

Social engineering may sound like a nifty term for techies involved in social media. It’s actually the practice of tricking people into divulging their confidential information, especially in situations where they normally wouldn’t. Phishing is one of the tac-



“How You Connect” is important for it determines how much you’re willing to share.

tics employed, wherein a user’s name, password, and other personal information is obtained by the “phisher” masquerading as a trusted source. This is often achieved by designing whole websites and pages to look like, say, your bank to get you to give up your personal information. Email spoofing can be considered more dangerous for social networkers. It involves altering the sender address or other parts of the email to make it appear as if it’s from a known source, even though it may have originated elsewhere. Given the number of notifications and alerts sent to our inboxes, it’s not a stretch for someone to just send you a mail, pretending to be Facebook or Twitter.

Detailing Facebook Security

Since it’s the most widely used social network in the world with 600 million users and rising, we’ll be covering the

security features of Facebook in detail. Keep in mind however that no matter which social network you use, you always give the security settings a once over.

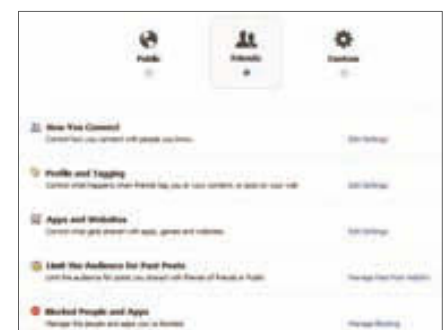
Firstly, navigate to the arrow located next to the “Home” button on the top of the page. Select Privacy settings.

You’ll see three settings for controlling what you share: Public (which makes all your profile info and pics available for everyone to see), Friends (limits your info to your circle of contacts and “friends of friends”) and Custom, wherein you can define parameters even more stringently.

Go to “How You Connect” and you’ll find options regarding who can look you up using your phone number and email address, and who can send friend requests and messages.

Ideally, you should set the first option to “Friends”, though it would be safer to limit this to a custom group. As you go along, you can add more names to said group depending on who you can trust. The last two options should be set to “Friends of Friends”, at least.

“Profile and Tagging” gets more extensive. It determines who can post on your wall, which friends can see those posts, the ability to review post tags, com-



Facebook offers three privacy settings for your discretion, though you’ll still need to do some fine-tuning.